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An Infinite Canvas for Living Traditions

India influenced global tastes and affairs for millennia, with what it imagined, crafted and transacted. Whether in royal collections or temple stores, gathered by connoisseurs or hoarders, India's treasures have always had takers. Today, the country is a vibrant living museum, and our infinite cultures are reflected in innumerable collections at home and overseas. A fast-developing economy is supercharging collectors, and enabling cultural professionals and entrepreneurs. At 75, the museums sector in India is undergoing a renaissance, an apt time to revisit breakthrough museums and archival centres since Independence.



National Museum

New Delhi

Described as 'an ocean' that many a venerable collection has flowed into, the National Museum first took shape in 1949. That Independence Day, an exhibition was mounted at the Rashtrapati Bhavan, of artefacts from Indian institutions returning after a show in London. The assemblage, by gift, loan and circumstance, became the nucleus of the museum. The Harappan section is a delight. With the momentum of India's G20 presidency accelerating, the recently-inaugurated galleries of Buddhist Art and Central Asian Art are expected to be at the top of diplomats' itineraries.
MUST DO: Sketch the sculptural treasures lining the National Museum corridors

